



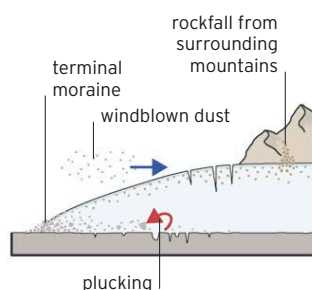
The Biafo Glacier

A long, nearly straight glacier in the Karakoram Mountains of Pakistan

The Biafo Glacier is a 39-mile- (63-km-) long glacier that runs northwest to southeast in a western region of the Karakoram (see p.225) and is heavily covered with rock debris on its lower parts. It is possible to walk along the entire length of the glacier, up to its highest point, at 16,824 ft (5,128 m). At its top end, the Biafo meets another highway of ice, the Hispar Glacier. Nearby is one of the largest basins of snow outside polar regions, known as Snow Lake. Occasionally, evidence of wildlife can also be seen in the vicinity of the glacier, including ibex and markhors (types of mountain goats) or, much more rarely, snow leopards.

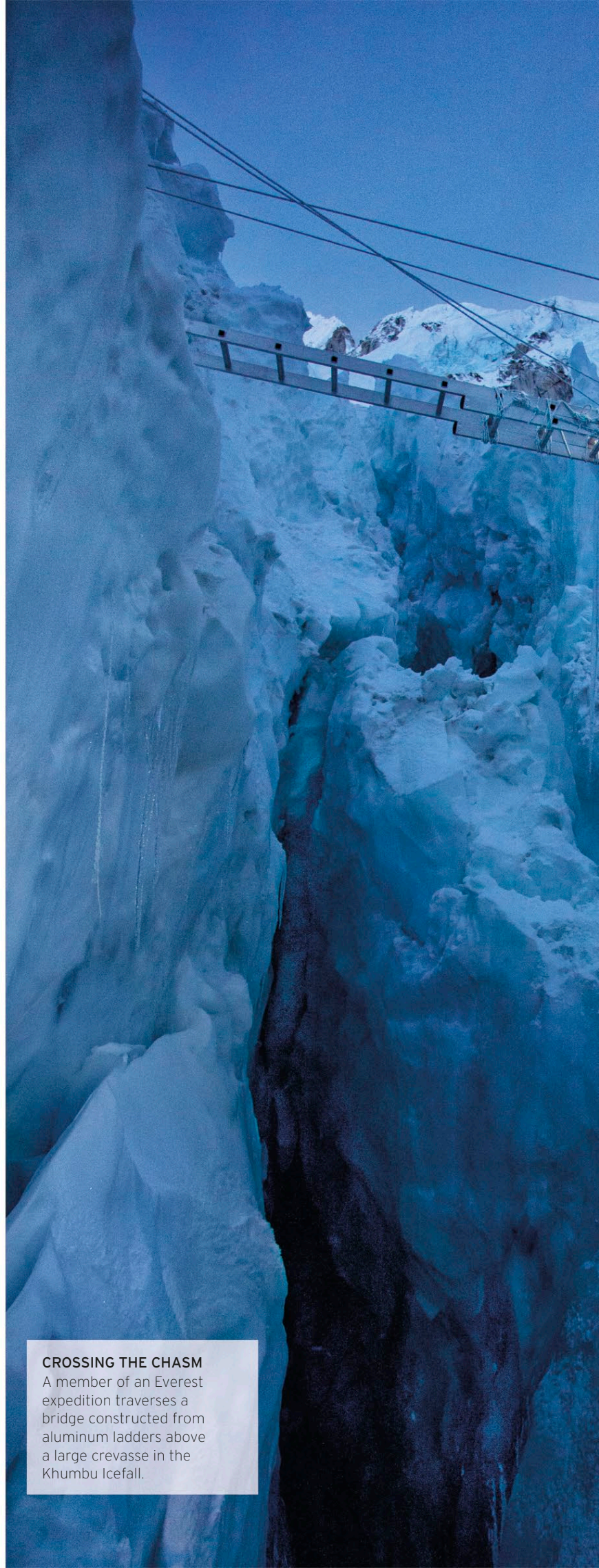
SOURCES OF DEBRIS IN GLACIERS

Rocks that have come loose from nearby mountains are the main source of debris in or on a glacier. Dust is also continuously blown onto the glacier surface, and rocks are "plucked" from the bedrock by becoming frozen onto the ice.



△ ICY HIGHWAY

The surface of the lower part of the glacier contains deep crevasses, meltwater streams, rock fragments, and large piles of rocks. Lines of high mountains with tributary glaciers run down both sides.



CROSSING THE CHASM

A member of an Everest expedition traverses a bridge constructed from aluminum ladders above a large crevasse in the Khumbu Icefall.